Out in the corridor, Dad and I met up with the United captain, Bryan Robson. We'd spent hours in front of the television watching videos of this man, our absolute all-time hero. Dad had tried to hammer his qualities into me: courage, commitment, energy, vision and the ability to inspire players around him.

I'd met Bryan before, but this was the boss introducing me to him as United's latest signing:

'Congratulations, David. You'll find out for yourself but, I'd say, you couldn't be joining a better club.'

I don't remember us driving back to London at all. At least Dad didn't forget we were on a busy highway. I couldn't have thought about anything else that evening, and I didn't want to. I'd just lived through the happiest day of my life.

Although I'd done the adding up in my head and got the answer I wanted, that first contract at Old Trafford wasn't actually for six years but for four. It was against regulations, anyway, for a boy signing schoolboy forms to have full professional terms set out there and then: I was only thirteen, after all, and so much could change before I turned eighteen. The rules were there to protect youngsters from getting trapped somewhere they didn't want to be; not that there was any chance of that happening to me. United told me that, if everything went well, I could expect to sign as a professional in four and a half years' time.

In a really important way, I think that bit of uncertainty was best for me and for all the other lads who joined the club at the same time. I knew I was wanted. But I also knew that I had to prove myself over the next four years. If I'd known all along that achieving the ambition of becoming a professional player at United was already settled—down on a piece of paper in black and white—who knows if it wouldn't have taken the edge off my determination to seize the chance I'd been given? I think that extra hunger has had a lot to do with my success and the team's success in the years since. The day I signed didn't feel like the day I'd made it. The hard work was just starting. I wanted a challenge and Manchester United was the biggest challenge there was.

I knew I was in good hands. Even before I signed at United I had the feeling I was joining a family. It's about there being really good people everywhere at the club. I don't just mean the ones everybody would know about like the manager or the players, but people like Kath Phipps, who still works on Reception at Old Trafford. I can still remember, when I was just a